

Vaccines and Immunization - World Health Organization

08/09/2026, 12:35 Vaccines and immunization

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Vaccines and
Immunization

Overview Impact WHO response

Immunization is a global health success story, saving millions of lives every year. Vaccines reduce risks of getting a disease by working with your body's natural defenses to build protection. When you get a vaccine, your immune system responds.

We now have vaccines to prevent more than 30 life-threatening diseases and infections, helping people of all ages live longer, healthier lives. Immunization currently prevents 3.5 million to 5 million deaths every year from diseases like diphtheria, tetanus, pertussis (whooping cough), influenza and measles.

Immunization is key to primary health care, an indisputable human right, and one of the best health investments money can buy. Vaccines are also critical to the prevention and control of infectious disease outbreaks. They underpin global health security and are a vital tool in the battle against antimicrobial resistance.

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The COVID-19 pandemic strained health systems, resulting in dramatic setbacks. The most recent data for diphtheria-pertussis-tetanus (DTP) immunization coverage underscores the need for ongoing catch-up, recovery and system-strengthening.

Measles, because of its high transmissibility, quickly exposes immunity. In 2025, the routine first dose of measles vaccine was missed by nearly 21 million children - far from the 2019 level of 19 million children.

Fact sheets

Questions and answers

Databases and tools

Resolutions and decisions

Initiatives and groups

Technical work

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News

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4 September 2026. | News release

WHO validates Bhutan for eliminating dog-transmitted human rabies

2 September 2026 | Joint News Release

Global initiative launched to improve access to mpox vaccines

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20 August 2026_ | News release

WHO and Africa CDC welcome the allocation of Ebola vaccines to the Democratic Republic of the Congo

23 July 2026_ | Departmental update

Momentum builds as countries accelerate action to defeat meningitis

Latest publications

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Vaccines, thiomersal and 3 September 2026

= Vaccines, thiomersal and autism spectrum disorder: evidence review 2010-2025

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WHO emergency guidance on the use of licensed Ebola vaccine during Bundibugyo

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18 August 2026

August 2026

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7 August 2026

Third meeting of the WHO Technical Advisory
Group on candidate vaccine prioritization

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Our work

Preparing and preventing epidemics and pandemics

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Immunizing against HPV

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Feature stories

22 April 2026

Five tips for preparing children for vaccination

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4 December 2025

Why childhood immunization schedules matter

30 October 2025

WHO: sustaining health services in Somalia amid unprecedented
funding challenges

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4 September 2025

What's in a vaccine?

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Infographics

Infographic

Countries with COVID-19 vaccination as 2025

Infographic

Malaria Vaccines (RTS,S/ASO1 and R21/Matrix-M)

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Infographic

Risk/Benefit considerations when deciding on CTC

Infographic

What is a Controlled Temperature Chain (CTC)?

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Videos

19 March 2026

Yours daily dose: Vaccines are your ally in staying healthy

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23 July 2025

WHO press conference on global health issues - 23 July 2025

2 July 2025

The Power of the HPV Vaccine - Manar's story

14 May 2025

Sudan: Malaria vaccination in times of conflict

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Podcasts

Episode #138 - The truth about vaccine safety

Are vaccines safe? What's actually in them? In this 2-part episode of Science in 5, WHO's Dr Kate O'Brien breaks down how vaccines are tested, approved, and monitored even after they reach the public. She also explains what happens if a safety concern is flagged.

Episode #137 - Vaccines: science vs. scare

Should kids just "get the disease" instead of being vaccinated? Can vaccines really overwhelm a child's immune system? Who decides what vaccines we get—and why? If you're a new parent with questions about vaccines, you're not alone. In this 2-part episode of Science in 5, WHO's Dr. Kate...

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Episode #70 - Upcoming new vaccines

What are the new vaccines in the pipeline? What are the challenges to turning vaccines into vaccination? What timelines can we expect for future vaccines? WHO's Dr Katherine O'Brien explains in Science in 5.

Episode #67 - Understanding immunity

WHO's Chief Scientist Dr Soumya Swaminathan explains how our body develops immunity against a new virus. How is immunity developed when we are infected with SARS-CoV-2 virus? How is it different from vaccine derived immunity? Why is it important to continue to wear masks, ventilate...

Spotlights

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Campaigns

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Events All —

gs 5 — 8 October 2026

Strategic Advisory Group of Experts on Immunization (SAGE) - October 2026

ms 15 — 18 March 2027

Strategic Advisory Group of Experts on Immunization (SAGE) - March 2027

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i 27 — 30 September 2027

Strategic Advisory Group of Experts on Immunization (SAGE) - September 2027

i 20 — 23 March 2028

Strategic Advisory Group of Experts on Immunization (SAGE) - March 2028

Related health topics

Non-communicable diseases

Cervical cancer

Diseases and conditions

Cholera

Communicable diseases

Coronavirus disease (COVID-19)

Diseases and conditions

Dengue and severe dengue

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Communicable diseases

Diphtheria

Communicable diseases

Hepatitis

Diseases and conditions

Influenza (seasonal)

Diseases and conditions

Malaria

Diseases and conditions

Measles

Communicable diseases

Meningitis

Diseases and conditions

Pertussis

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Diseases and conditions

Pneumonia

Diseases and conditions

Poliomyelitis (polio)

Diseases and conditions

Rabies

Diseases and conditions

Tick-borne encephalitis

Diseases and conditions

Tuberculosis

Diseases and conditions

Typhoid

Diseases and conditions

Yellow fever

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